

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Federal change on marijuana may aid Ill.

Effects for consumers could take time

By Robert McCoppin
Chicago Tribune

A renewed federal push to relax restrictions on marijuana likely will mean bigger profits for cannabis companies and more research into the effects of the plant, industry participants say. It may eventually ease high prices slightly, but otherwise isn't expected to make an immediate difference for consumers in Illinois.

That's because weed already is legal under Illinois state law. The new proposed federal classification would allow doctors to prescribe FDA-approved cannabis products, rather than just recommending it, and research eventually could result in better understanding of the plant's effects and proper use.

President Donald Trump's executive order Dec. 18 did not legalize cannabis, but directed the attorney general to change its classification as a controlled substance from the most serious designation of Schedule I, on par with heroin and LSD, to Schedule III, the same class as codeine, ketamine and steroids.

The change was put in motion when President Joe Biden's administration proposed rescheduling in 2022, but the process was bogged down before the U.S. Drug Enforcement Administration. It's uncertain how much longer the lengthy process will take.

The main immediate effect would be that cannabis businesses for the first time will be able to take normal business tax deductions for expenses. That could cut in half tax rates that now reach 70% to 80%, said cannabis attorney Scott Redman, president of the Illinois Independent Craft Growers Association.

"The tax part is huge," Redman said. "Just imagine your own tax returns if you had no deductions. It makes the business more viable. That can only help businesses get

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A Union Pacific freight train crosses over Interstate 290 on Dec. 8. Union Pacific plans to double the number of trains on a 2-mile stretch of track on Chicago's West Side. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Union Pacific's plan to add trains raises alarms

Proposal increases traffic on dilapidated tracks, century-old bridges on Chicago's West Side

By John Lippert
Chicago Tribune

To make money on its proposed cross-country railroad, Union Pacific plans to double the number of trains on a 2-mile stretch of track on Chicago's West Side where workers still throw switches by hand and trains crawl across century-old bridges at less than 15 miles per hour.

The railroad plans to add 12 trains per day on these dilapidated tracks, which run along

Rockwell Avenue through North Lawndale and West Town.

After reaching Lake Street on the north, the additional trains will turn west and run 13 miles to a Union Pacific rail yard in Melrose Park. They'll have to thread their way through 58 passenger trains and up to 24 freight trains, which, according to Metra and Chicago Metropolitan Agency for Planning data, are running on these same tracks each weekday now.

Union Pacific outlined these and many similar changes nation-

wide in a 6,692-page application on Friday for federal approval of its proposed \$85 billion merger with Norfolk Southern. If regulators say yes, the investor-owned railroad would carry nearly half of all U.S. rail freight.

The proposed traffic increases, and the additional trucks they'll pump onto some of the already-congested and polluted streets and highways nearby, are setting off alarm bells in Chicago and surrounding suburbs.

"Adding 12 trains is a lot," said

Earl Wacker, a former CSX executive who now works with RINA North America, an environmental consultancy with offices in Chicago. "It's going to have a pretty significant impact unless they add more capacity."

According to the Union Pacific application, four of the additional trains will continue west past Melrose Park through the heart of DuPage and Kane counties. They'll join the 58 Metra trains

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Grant Inglis, 12, is in snow while shaking off Christmas trees with Trent Modglin on Dec. 7 at Centennial Park in Park Ridge. The Wilderness Scouts and Princesses run the lot annually for charity. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Dreaming of a gray Christmas?

Thursday's forecast — and what climate change means for the holidays

By Adriana Pérez
Chicago Tribune

Monday evening at a packed Christkindlmarket in downtown Chicago, tourists and locals alike rushed to finish their holiday shopping — ears tucked under mufflers and hats, necks and chins hidden behind large scarves and hands stashed away in puffy coats or holding hot drinks, all in an effort to stave off the freezing temps. But that's about as festive

as the weather will be this week in the city.

On Christmas Day, the only thing blanketing Chicago rooftops will likely be fog, and the only thing falling from the sky might be an intermittent drizzle. Meteorologists are forecasting no snow in the Chicago area on Christmas Eve or Christmas Day. Rather, temperatures will be unseasonably warm in the 40- to 50-degree range.

Typically, Chicago has a white

Christmas about once every three to four years, but it has only experienced one in the past seven. That was 2022, and even then, it barely qualified with 1 inch of snow.

"Everybody's always like, 'We don't get winters like we used to,'" said Judah Cohen, a research scientist at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology, whose research focuses on snow and winter climate. "You remem-

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Trump fuels anger in ally Denmark

Pick of special envoy to Greenland revives annexation dispute

By Amelia Nierenberg,
Jeffrey Gettleman
and Maya Tekeli
The New York Times

COPENHAGEN, Denmark — Officials in Denmark and Greenland were furious Monday that President Donald Trump had appointed a special envoy to Greenland, part of his efforts to take over the semiautonomous Danish territory.

Trump announced on social media late Sunday that he was appointing Republican Gov. Jeff Landry of Louisiana, a political ally, to the position. Denmark's foreign minister quickly criticized the move as "totally unacceptable" and said he would summon the U.S. ambassador in Copenhagen for an explanation. It appeared to be the first time

the United States had appointed a special envoy to Greenland. That puts the island of fewer than 60,000 inhabitants in a small group of foreign policy priorities, including Ukraine and the Middle East, for which Trump has appointed trusted allies.

Landry quickly made it clear that he understood what Trump wanted from him, writing on X: "It's an honor to serve you in this volunteer position to make Greenland a part of the U.S."

Most of Greenland lies within the Arctic Circle, where world powers are competing for control of the top of the world to access untapped natural resources and emerging shipping corridors.

Greenland has critical minerals that have attracted the interest of top officials in the Trump administration, and it served as a base for U.S. military operations

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Property tax hike taken off agenda

Chicago Board of Education President Sean Harden pulled a proposed property tax hike from the school board's agenda last week. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Dem. lawmakers tour Broadview

A group of Democratic Illinois lawmakers made it inside the U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement processing center. **Page 7**

